



rides wind gently through the estate. Families gravitate to the PetZone, home to Punganur cows, goats, rabbits and, rather improbably, emus, while rainy afternoons belong to the games room and its giant carrom board. For a longer excursion, the drive to Talakaveri, the source of the Kaveri, is well worth the morning.

Holding it all together is the service. My butler unpacked my bags and, by the second evening, knew exactly how I take my coffee. Wait staff remembered preferences without being reminded, and a guest experience coordinator shaped an itinerary that was generous but never rigid. Nothing is pushed; everything is offered.

THE ART OF BALANCE

If the kitchen feeds the palate, Aujasya by The Leela Spa restores everything else. Spread across 27,000 square feet, with outdoor treatment spaces set into the greenery, it is built on a "Trinity of Balance": Shakti for vitality, Shanti for stillness and Soumya for radiance. Treatments feel like intuitive journeys rather than set menus, drawing on Ayurveda alongside global therapies.

I began in the Turkish hammam, the only one in the region, lying on heated marble while therapists scrubbed and polished away the city. The next day brought shirodhara, a slow stream of warm oil across the forehead that quietened a mind that rarely stops travelling. The 90-minute Aujasya Signature Ritual weaves herbal therapies, rhythmic oil work and moments of sound and silence. At dusk, the Vinyasa Yoga Deck above the lake hosts pranayama and sound healing as the light fades. For a taster, a reset palate is no small gift.

THE LAST POUR

Luxury, I believe, is attention: to ingredients, to origin, to the guest. The Leela Coorg Forest Sanctuary understands this. It lets Coorg speak through its coffee, its kitchen, its glass and its healing traditions. I came for the forest. I left with a richer vocabulary of flavour.

Getting there About five hours by road from Bengaluru; nearest airport, Mysuru
Cost Villas Upwards of ₹50,000 a night

